

Well Healed

FELDENKRAIS METHOD Threatened with disability, Moshe Feldenkrais, an Israeli physicist, used scientific knowledge to heal himself. Thus developed the Feldenkrais Method in 1929. At least 10-12 sessions recommended. Cost per session: Rs 250-500.

ALEXANDER TECHNIQUE F. Matthias Alexander, a Shakespearean actor, lost his voice. He used empirical scientific methods of breathing habitual patterns of body movement to find what came to be known as the Alexander Technique. About 12-15 one-on-one sessions cost Rs 12,000-15,000.

DANCE THERAPY Integrating movement and medicine, it helps relieve pain and alleviate suffering. Workshops cost upwards of Rs 5,000 while classes cost Rs 1,000-2,000 per month.

SOUND HEALING Administered by a variety of stringed or wind instruments one of which is the Nidranantar, a hollow wooden bed with strings underneath. The strings are tuned to a certain frequency and played by the therapist to release energy and help in healing. An hour's session costs over Rs 1,000.

ART THERAPY A worldwide movement uses clay, paper, colour and paints for detection, diagnosis and treatment of mental illnesses.



(FROM LEFT) A DANCE-CUM-HEALING SESSION IN PROGRESS; MENON WITH A STUDENT; RAMAKRISHNAN PLAYS THE HEALING STRINGS OF THE NIDRANANTAR FOR A PATIENT

West, including the AT, the FM and several variations of dance, art and music therapies, that are becoming popular in countries like India.

Both AT and FM require intense training, a study period ranging from three to five years. Training for both techniques is not available in this part of the globe. Menon, who attended the Brighton Alexander Technique College, says, "It is a three-year full time course and one is expected to put in over 1,600 hours of training." Michel Cassanovas, on the other hand, spends half his time in Bangalore as a practitioner of FM, and the rest travelling as a contemporary dancer and choreographer in Europe. "I had injured my back while dancing ballet. I was told there was no cure, but FM worked for me. It is then that I decided to train and become a practi-

tioner. It takes nearly four years to become a fully-trained practitioner." Cassanovas has so far travelled to Bangalore, Mumbai, Delhi and other parts of India where he administers one-on-one or group sessions. "FM is used for the reduction of pain, and to restore abilities in the case of orthopaedic or neurological problems, while artistes like dancers and musicians use it to further their craft and common people find more ease and comfort, less struggle and a better quality of moving after practising it," says Cassanovas. Both Menon and Cassanovas are quick to add that neither of the techniques are meant to be a substitute for medical help though a more open approach has ensured that techniques like AT and FM are now covered by medical insurance in many countries, including the UK and

Switzerland. Thanks to recent interest in FM in countries like India, the Feldenkrais Guild is planning to start a centre in India to help train both practitioners as well as trainers.

It is a well-known fact that Art for Art's sake was a worldwide movement and now it is art for therapeutic purposes that has gained worldwide acceptance. Therapists believe that the act of creation in painting, sketching and drawing influences brain wave patterns and the chemicals released by the brain. This has led to the increasing use of artwork as a diagnostic tool with children and adolescents, who have trouble talking about painful events or trauma. Dr Nandini Mundkur, director, Centre for Child Development and Disabilities, Bangalore, has been using art as a tool in early detection, healing, and management of disabilities in children for almost three decades now. She has been involved in conducting workshops across the country as well as in convincing the medical community of art as an effective tool of not just communication but also healing. Her work with children at the centre is a clear indicator of the power of art. In Europe and America, only trained professionals are eligible to practice as licensed art therapists where there is a clear distinction between artists and doctors using art as a tool of healing. The